



Opera with VPN

Opera browser for public now with unlimited VPN service included, first of its kind. <http://dgit.in/OprVPN>



Halo Smart launched

Priced at ₹3499, the Jabra Halo Smart stereo headphones provides battery life of up to 17 hours.

Dealing with design

We learn the secrets of design from one of the biggest ticketing services in India



Mithun Mohandas

mithun@digit.in

Q Going in for a complete redesign in a short period or a staggered approach where you keep making minor modifications till you reach a complete redesign in roughly a year's time. Which school of thought do you follow or do you have a separate belief?

Anish: I go with the first one, also with the incremental one only when the need is vital; here at BMS we do a lot of incremental vital changes. These incremental changes are fine for performance and to add more value to the consumer and for us to make features that meet our goals.

As for my personal stance, I would stick with an overhaul because just like a painting, the design is only perceived the right way once it's ready. When you are in that mindset, especially if you are a designer, you have all your tools and all their prior knowledge in and around them. In that context, an overhaul is better. I repeat this with my designers at BMS day in or day out. If they are designing anything, they would do a great job at it but if you revisit the design later, you may want to make changes. And this an incremental approach may take up a lot of time in the long run. But those are sort of one offs unless they are measurable. Hence, here in BMS we keep a clear segregation that if there's going to be an incremental change then it should be measurable if it's not then overhaul it and analyse what was right and what was wrong.

Q So if you do an overhaul wouldn't you end up alienating your current user base or at least a significant portion which might go to the competition just because they still retain familiarity.



Anish Tripathi, AVP Product Design at Bookmyshow.com

Anish: Actually when we redesign a website we have the same question. Should we change or just overhaul? If you look at BMS we redesigned it, completely overhauled it, by that I mean we rewrote the code, redesigned the way people interacted with it but we identified the one thing that we didn't change, keeping the booking flow linear.

We worked on overhauling without any major behavioural change. I agree with some of the designers you have spoken to, I don't think any designer in their right mind would like to stop that behavioural change, especially at our scale in BMS. I think that would be very dangerous. It was very tricky but we achieved it and transactions have gone up after the redesign.

Q Could you share some information on your user feedback system?

Anish: I learnt one thing in my previous organisation, whenever we had to sign up customers or whenever we had an invite-only program, you get a lot of people coming to you only because they want to know what's behind the walled garden. We have a similar

feedback system, which I've termed as the "Secret Society" just because people want to be a part of it. We have sessions where we interact with customers to gain insight and genuine feedback and in return we provide gift vouchers. We have workshops as well where you get to see some of the new things that we are working on, some of the new interfaces that we want to validate.

There are certain features which are live right now which the users have asked for and our designers have come up with an exploration which might have been rejected. Showing them different explorations, getting them actual prototypes that they can interact with, doing a proper movie booking flow and buying a proper ticket are all performed to gain valuable user feedback.

Q How do you figure out that perfect balance between speed and visual fidelity without compromising the whole user experience?

Anish: Most of our device based decisions are taken based on feedback. Certain devices aren't high-performance but should we ignore them? No! Should we have a different experience for them? Yes! We are currently working on a lite version which is basically based upon your data connection and based upon your region.

We experiment as to how they would look like on 2G connections or on a 3G connection in a particular region. I'm even going to Gujarat where our goal is to plant ourselves there and do consumer behaviour research and we are very excited for the same. Maybe by the end-of-the-year we will do a proper India tour where we go to every city to complete our research. We are working on delivering solutions based upon the devices where engagement is considerably high. **Q**